



WE HEAR YOUR OUTCRY!

EPIISODE 1: DRUGS, AIDS AND AWARENESS !!



INTRODUCTION :

- SPEAKER'S NAME : MRS. SHANTA THEBEY
- SEX : FEMALE
- NUMBER OF CHILDREN : 2
- DATE OF BIRTH (B.S) : 2034/02/17
- SPOUSE'S NAME : LATE RAM CHANDRA THEBEY
- ADDRESS : NAYA BANESHWOR, KATHMANDU
- EDUCATION/PROFESSION : UNDERGRADUATE / HOUSE-WIFE
- CONTACT NUMBER : (SPEAKER'S CHOICE OF PRIVACY)

1. HOW DID YOU GET INFECTED WITH HIV/AIDS?

Speaker: (* Joins her hands and says “Namaskar!” *)



I am the second individual in my family to be affected by HIV/AIDS, fortunately, also the last. The genesis of this journey traces back to my late husband, who, unbeknownst to me for several years into our marriage, battled drug addiction. He regularly consumed tablets and, on occasion, used **Syringes**. Tragically, it was through the use of a contaminated syringe that he contracted HIV/AIDS. Subsequently, the virus was transmitted to me through intimate contact.

Our awareness of this devastating disease only dawned upon us upon receiving my husband's death certificate. He passed away at the untimely age of 36. Following his demise, the doctor advised comprehensive HIV testing for all family members to confirm the presence of the virus. Regrettably, I tested positive, but fortunately, my two children tested negative. It is from this juncture that my arduous journey begins.

WHAT CHALLENGES HAVE YOU FACED SINCE BEING DIAGNOSED WITH HIV/AIDS?

SPEAKER: (**Takes a long breath**)

Living as a single mom and an HIV patient in Nepali society is an extraordinary challenge, marked by both societal and personal hurdles. In a society that often adheres to traditional norms, the journey as a single mother of 2 children is met with its share of stereotypes and judgment. The expectations placed on me to conform to traditional family structures was isolating and emotionally taxing, adding an additional layer of difficulty to the already demanding role of a single parent. As a single mom and an HIV patient, navigating through these societal expectations becomes even more intricate, which intensified the sense of isolation and discrimination. (contd..)



CONTD...

.....The dual role of a single mom and an individual living with HIV/AIDS brought about an array of practical challenges. Accessing healthcare and essential resources while shouldering the responsibilities of parenthood can be an overwhelming juggling act. The societal misconceptions surrounding HIV/AIDS may also lead to limited support networks, making it harder for me to find understanding and empathy. Additionally, the financial strain of managing medical expenses coupled with the responsibilities of my children.

However, Many single moms like me with HIV in Nepal, despite the hardships, find ways to defy societal expectations, access support systems, and contribute to changing perceptions. By shedding light on the complexities of their journey, we have been working towards breaking down stigmas, fostering empathy, and advocating for a more inclusive and supportive society for all.

*(*Gives a heartwarming yet painful smile..*)*



HOW HAS THE STIGMA AROUND HIV/AIDS AFFECTED YOUR LIFE?

SPEAKER: *(*Soft laugh , then pause*)*

The stigma surrounding the condition has profoundly influenced various aspects of my life. One of the most significant impacts has been on my interpersonal relationships. My own biological Mother and Father refused to Touch me and provide me any support, they even rejected my kids. The judgment and discrimination often made it challenging to disclose my HIV status even to my own relatives and friends which lead to a sense of isolation for years. This fear contribute to a feeling of loneliness, as the stigma becomes a barrier to genuine understanding and support also I lost my husband....(contd..)



CONTD..

.....In the broader societal context, the prevailing misconceptions about HIV/AIDS have subjected me to unfair treatment and discrimination as I mentioned early. From employment opportunities to social interactions, the stigma has cast a shadow on various facets of my life. Educating others about the realities of living with HIV/AIDS is an ongoing effort, as dispelling myths and fostering awareness is crucial in dismantling the stigma that persists.

Moreover, Overcoming the shame associated with HIV/AIDS is an ongoing journey, requiring resilience and a commitment to self-acceptance and now my children supports me and some relatives have understood me too. The stigma's influence extends beyond the medical aspect of living with a chronic condition, affecting emotional well-being and the ability to lead a fulfilling life free from judgment.

*(*Remembering all the struggles her Eyes are full of tears*)*



WHAT SUPPORT SYSTEM HAVE BEEN IMPORTANT TO YOU IN DEALING WITH HIV/AIDS?

Speaker :

My support system has played a crucial role in navigating the challenges associated with the condition. Firstly, my family, my own children has been an anchor, providing emotional support and understanding. Their willingness to educate themselves about HIV/AIDS and stand by me in the face of societal stigma has been invaluable. Even though they were at the age of 8-9 they understood their mother's pain and motivated me after the demise of their father. (**Cries**).. Open communication within the family gives the feeling of acceptance and love, creating a foundation for coping with the emotional aspects of my journey... (**PAUSE**)..... (contn...)



CONTD..

... And the healthcare professionals in Kathmandu have also been instrumental in my support system. Regular check-ups, access to antiretroviral therapy, and a collaborative approach to managing my health have been vital components of this support system. Additionally, community organizations and support groups specific to HIV/AIDS in Kathmandu have been a source of strength and helps me provide my required medicines at heavy discounts.

In summary, my support system in Kathmandu revolves around the pillars of family, healthcare professionals, community organizations, and few friends that I made here in this **Sukraraj Tropical & Infectious Disease Hospital**. Together, we form a network that empowers me to face the challenges of HIV/AIDS with resilience and optimism.



CAN YOU SHARE ANY MISCONCEPTIONS OR MYTHS ABOUT HIV/AIDS THAT YOU HAVE ENCOUNTERED ?

Speaker : (** Remembers and shakes her head in disbelief **)

As an HIV/AIDS patient for 16 years and living with HIV/AIDS in Nepali society, I have encountered several **misconceptions and myths**. One prevalent misconception is the belief that **HIV/AIDS can be transmitted through casual contact**. Many people still harbor the misunderstanding that activities like sharing utensils, hugging, or even being in the same room as someone with HIV can lead to transmission. It was really heartbreaking to see my own people hating me and getting disgust.

Another **misconception is associating HIV/AIDS solely with certain marginalized groups or specific behaviors**. Some believe that only certain lifestyles or communities are at risk(prostitutes). The truth is that HIV/AIDS can affect anyone, regardless of their background, sexual orientation, or lifestyle choices. They need to understand that the virus does not discriminate, and everyone is susceptible. (contd..)



CONTD....

There is also a prevailing belief that a person with **HIV/AIDS looks visibly sick or emaciated**. People may assume that someone appearing healthy cannot be living with the virus. In reality, individuals with HIV/AIDS can lead healthy and productive lives, especially with access to proper medical care and treatment. Look at me I look totally healthy and have been surviving AIDS since 16 years now.

Also there's misconception about the effectiveness of antiretroviral therapy (ART) and medicines in managing HIV/AIDS. Some people believe that **once diagnosed, there is no hope for a normal life**. In truth, with timely and consistent medical care, including ART, individuals with HIV can lead long, healthy lives and maintain a suppressed viral load, reducing the risk of transmission. Me including my friends are the proof .

*(* she smiles with pride * and says I forgot other things..)*



WHAT ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE TO OTHERS WHO HAVE RECENTLY BEEN DIAGNOSED WITH HIV/AIDS?

Speaker : (**Shakes her head and says with excitement “ Here comes the important part “ and everyone laughs**)

As a female living with HIV/AIDS in a society with prevalent superstitions like Nepal, navigating the complexities can be particularly challenging. But here's what I would like to advice:

- **Educate Yourself:** Knowledge is empowering. Take the time to educate yourself about HIV/AIDS, including its modes of transmission, treatment options, and how to live a healthy life with the virus. Being informed will not only help you make informed decisions about your health but will also enable you to dispel myths and misinformation. I think you will suffer less mental instability.(contd..)



CONTD...

- **Address Mental Health:** Don't hesitate to seek professional mental health support if needed. Counseling or therapy can provide a safe space to process your emotions, fears, and anxieties, helping you navigate the psychological aspects of living with the virus and community.
- **Seek Professional Support:** Connect with healthcare professionals who specialize in HIV/AIDS care. Establishing a relationship with a knowledgeable and supportive healthcare team helps for managing your health effectively. They can guide you through treatment options, address your concerns, and provide emotional support.
- **Build a Support Network:** Share your diagnosis with trusted friends and family members who are understanding and non-judgmental. Having a supportive network is vital for emotional well-being. They even help you to get required medicines with heavy discounts.



CONTD..



- **Empower Yourself:** Recognize that you are not defined by your diagnosis. Take charge of your health by adhering to your treatment plan, attending regular medical check-ups, and making lifestyle choices that promote overall well-being. Empower yourself with the knowledge that, with proper care, individuals with HIV/AIDS can lead fulfilling lives.
- **Advocate for Awareness:** If you feel comfortable, consider becoming an advocate for HIV/AIDS awareness in your community. Sharing your story can help break down stereotypes, dispel myths, and contribute to a more informed and compassionate society. Well, that's what I have experienced. (** gives another heartwarming smile **)

Nevertheless, By sharing my story, correcting misconceptions, and contributing to community initiatives, I strive to break down the barriers of stigma and pave the way for a more empathetic and supportive environment for individuals living with HIV/AIDS. (** another heartwarming smile**)

HOW DO YOU ENVISION THE FUTURE IN TERMS OF HIV/AIDS AWARENESS AND TREATMENT?

Speaker : (* A long pause and says “ hm... future.....”)

Now, I might now live longer to see what future really holds and how soon the conditions for people like us will change but, envisioning the future as someone living with HIV/AIDS, I see a world where awareness has eradicated stigma and misinformation. I anticipate advancements in treatment, making it more accessible and less invasive, contributing to improved quality of life. A future with open conversations and comprehensive sexual education could lead to early testing and diagnosis. Ultimately, my vision is for a society that embraces understanding, compassion, and universal access to care, fostering an environment where individuals with HIV/AIDS can live with dignity and opportunity.

(And her eyes shine bright as she hopes for the better future *)*

